

Steppe — Proposed Operating Budget (staged)

v1 • July 2026 • PROPOSED — planning numbers, not commitments. Living document: the founding cohort and board ratify or amend these figures; update at each stage gate and whenever a real invoice replaces an estimate. Companion to Business Plan v12 (§04 revenue ladder, §07 dues, §08 stewards) and the Funder Eligibility Reference v3. Fiscal sponsor: **Ignite Empowerment Foundation (IEF) — confirmed**; the sponsorship agreement is pending signature and the sponsor admin fee below is a planning placeholder until it is signed. **Related-party note:** Director Brandon Weimer is the spouse of IEF's founder, so the Steppe-IEF terms (admin fee, fund flows) are an interested-person matter, to be approved by the disinterested directors with Mr. Weimer recused (COI Register, Entry 002).

Purpose. BP v12 asserts “dues alone carry core operations at every rung” but no document derived it. This table makes the claim checkable — and it surfaces the one place the current policy arithmetic doesn't close (moderator honoraria; see §4).

1 • The stages (from Business Plan v12)

Stage	Members	Dues revenue (@ \$4/mo flat)	Period (planning)
0 • Prototype / closed beta	0 paying (cohort is free)	\$0	2026
1 • Public launch base	200	\$9,600/yr	late 2026 → 2027
2 • First plateau	500	\$24,000/yr	2027
3 • Growth	1,000	\$48,000/yr	2027-28
4 • Comp-ceiling threshold	~2,300	~\$110,000/yr	2028+

2 • Annual operating costs by stage (planning numbers)

Core = what dues must carry (the survivability rule). Program = grant-fundable, never load-bearing.

Line (annual)	Stage 0	Stage 1 (200)	Stage 2 (500)	Stage 3 (1,000)	Stage 4 (~2,300)	Basis
CORE						
Hosting & infra (Supabase, host, domain, DNS)	\$600	\$900	\$1,200	\$1,800	\$3,000	Supabase Pro ≈\$300; host plan grows with traffic; Package A's year-one \$1,500 line is grant-covered free tier → paid as volume grows
Transactional email (Resend)	\$0	\$240	\$240	\$480	\$700	Package A funds year one (\$1,500); renewals are core
D&O insurance	\$0 ¹	\$1,500	\$1,500	\$1,600	\$1,800	

Line (annual)	Stage 0	Stage 1 (200)	Stage 2 (500)	Stage 3 (1,000)	Stage 4 (~2,300)	Basis
State/IRS compliance (OR DOJ CT-12, 990-N→990-EZ, registered agent)	\$100	\$300	\$500	\$1,200	\$2,000	990-N free ≤\$50K gross; CPA-prepared 990-EZ from Stage 3
Payment processing on dues (~4% planning; annual/ACH billing)	\$0	\$400	\$960	\$1,900	\$4,400	2.9%+30¢ card on \$48/yr ≈3.5%; ACH cheaper — 4% is conservative
Misc (tools, print, tabling)	\$150	\$250	\$400	\$600	\$1,000	
Core subtotal	\$850	\$3,590	\$4,800	\$7,580	\$12,900	
Dues cover core?	n/a (no dues)	YES — 2.7×	YES — 5.0×	YES — 6.3×	YES — 8.5×	the BP claim, now derived
PROGRAM / POLICY (grant- or surplus-funded)						
Moderator honoraria (3 stewards; see §4)	\$0 (volunteer)	\$1,800 ²	\$1,920 ³	\$3,600	\$3,600	floor 3×\$50/mo; cap per §4 resolution
Moderator training	\$1,000 ²	\$500	\$500	\$750	\$1,000	Package A year one
Legal (formation year one; then episodic)	\$3,000 ²	\$500	\$750	\$1,000	\$1,500	Package A funds the \$3,000
Bilingual access / a11y program	grant	grant	grant	grant	grant	never core, per BP
Sponsor admin fee (only while fiscally sponsored; on sponsor-routed funds)	8% of grants ²	8%	— (own 501(c)(3))	—	—	placeholder until the IEF agreement fixes the rate
ED compensation (ceiling \$95K)	\$0	\$0	\$0	partial, if board approves	at ceiling only at ~2,300	BP v12 §04; academic income carries the founder until the salary is demonstrated

¹ Stage 0 has no insurable operations until launch; bind D&O at first public launch. ² Grant-funded in year one via the Package A lines (MasterCase §05): hosting \$1,500, D&O \$1,500, legal \$3,000, moderator training \$1,000, sponsor admin 8%. ³ See §4 — the current 8%-of-opex cap cannot fund even the floor at early stages.

3 · Revenue recap against the stages

Source	Stage 0	1	2	3	4
Dues (\$4/mo flat, hardship waiver via Member Access Fund)	\$0	\$9.6K	\$24K	\$48K	~\$110K
Founding Supporters (one-time, launch)	\$5-10K goal	—	—	—	—
Foundation grants (Roundhouse ≤\$2.5K small / ≤\$30K Open Call per FE v3; OCF \$15-20K typical; Ford Family ≤\$25K w/ 25% match; Bend Fdn; Deschutes Cultural \$1-3K)	pipeline	pipeline	pipeline	tapering	episodic
Government (2028+, ≤25% of revenue, infrastructure only)	—	—	—	—	fenced
Earned (visitor listing fees, replication support)	—	—	—	unnumbered until a counterparty exists	”

Guardrails that bind this budget: **no single funder >30%** (§5 of the funding strategy needs a ramp rule for 2026-27 — flagged there); **dues fund core, always**; government money never core.

4 · The honoraria arithmetic — resolution (needs Charter §8.9 amendment)

Current policy: \$50-100/month per moderator, three-moderator minimum (BP §08; Charter 8.9), **capped at 8% of operating expenses**. The floor ($3 \times \$50 \times 12 = \$1,800/\text{yr}$) is only permitted by the cap at $\text{opex} \geq \$22,500/\text{yr}$ — which no early stage reaches. As written, the policy cannot pay the minimum it promises.

Resolution (adopted as this budget’s planning basis; requires board/cohort ratification and a matching amendment to Charter §8.9): honoraria = **the greater of the \$1,800/yr floor or 8% of core opex**, hard-capped at \$100/mo/moderator, and **grant-funded until Stage 2** (own-determination + \$24K dues), after which dues surplus may carry it. This keeps stewards paid from day one without breaching the dues-cover-core rule. **Charter §8.9 (the flat 8%-of-opex cap) must be amended to this rule so the two documents agree** — flagged in the review annex and noted at §8.9.

5 • Deliberately not specified here

No five-year pro-forma, no month-level cash-flow, no audited-statement theater — the plan's discipline is its credibility. This document stays one page of derivable numbers; the next revision replaces estimates with actuals as invoices land (hosting, IEF fee, insurance quote) and records the honoraria ratification.

Changelog - v1.1 (2026-07-08) — fiscal sponsor confirmed as Ignite Empowerment Foundation with a related-party note (Director Weimer is the spouse of IEF's founder); honoraria fix adopted as the planning basis and flagged for a matching Charter §8.9 amendment. - v1 (2026-07-04) — first derivation; created from the strategy audit's finding that no operating budget existed anywhere in the doc set.